

table. Days later, I was told that she had made me the executor of her estate. After years working for the United Nations, she and George had enjoyed a textured life, rich in experiences, travel, friends, and fine food, but their lifestyle was by no means overly lavish. They mostly lived on George's solid UN income, so my mother's money was hers to invest and spend. She never merged it with her husband's. That money was all her own, and George didn't even know how much she had. Keeping some money separate for you and only you is one of the best financial lessons I can impart to you. (I'll talk more about that and what I call your "Secret 10" in Chapter 6.) But at the time of my mother's death, I hadn't given this idea much thought. Mostly, I never imagined that Georgette's savings amounted to much. But when I opened the books and studied her long-term investment portfolio, I got a big surprise. She'd amassed the kind of nest egg with which most people could enjoy a worry-free, exciting retirement. By the looks of her portfolio activity, she mostly invested and rarely spent. She didn't set aside considerable chunks of cash, just a steady amount every month, and only in *stocks or securities that paid her a dividend or a yield*.

When people talked about investing like this, I always thought they were talking about another era. But do you have any idea what happens to a portfolio over forty years that contains only bonds with interest and stocks with dividends? You have to see it to believe it. My mother's portfolio was a sweeping, arcing line tracing value over time—it only went up—and her balance steadily grew and multiplied at an incredible rate. When I analyzed my mother's secret cache, when I studied her slow and steady investment style and the healthy nest egg she'd tucked away for herself, here's what I learned: With very little money and a bit of expertise, anyone can grow his or her money. My mother did it. So can you.